What happens to democracy when public anger grows but the government refuses to respond?

GS II - Governance
Democratic Accountability and Electoral Institutions

KNOWLEDGE POINTS

- **Public Trust Weakens:** When people repeatedly raise concerns but receive no meaningful response, they may lose faith in the government and public institutions. Democracy becomes weaker because citizens begin doubting whether their voices matter.
- **Protests May Intensify:** When peaceful protests fail to bring change, public frustration can grow. More people may join demonstrations, and tensions may increase. The editorial warns that continued resistance could make future protests harder to control.
- **Democratic Accountability Suffers:** Elections allow citizens to choose governments, but democracy also requires leaders to listen between elections. When governments dismiss public concerns, citizens may struggle to hold those in power accountable for their decisions.
- **Institutional Independence:** Institutions such as the Election Commission must make decisions fairly, without political pressure. When people question their independence, confidence in elections can decline. Independent institutions help ensure that governments follow democratic rules.
- **Peaceful Protest Rights:** Citizens can express disagreement through peaceful protests. Article 19 of the Indian Constitution protects freedom of speech and peaceful assembly, subject to reasonable restrictions. These freedoms allow people to question government decisions between elections.

CONCEPT UNFOLD

Public consent gives democratic governments their authority

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Authority Needs Acceptance

Winning elections gives governments legal power, but public acceptance helps them govern effectively. When citizens lose confidence, government decisions may face stronger resistance.

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Legitimacy Can Decline

A government may remain legally in power even when many citizens question its decisions. This creates a gap between holding authority and being trusted.

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Dialogue Builds Consent

Public consent is strengthened when governments explain decisions, hear criticism and address reasonable concerns. Such dialogue helps citizens accept decisions even when they disagree.

KEY TAKEAWAY

Ignoring growing public anger can deepen the distance between citizens and their government. As trust declines and protests intensify, democracy becomes vulnerable because elected leaders are no longer seen as responsive to people.